CHAPTER 6 · DEEP DIVE · HOUSE & DIVIDED

John Brown & Harpers Ferry

A man willing to kill — and die — to end slavery. Hero, madman, or martyr? 1859.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

A man willing to kill — and die — to end slavery. Hero, madman, or martyr? 1859.

When a cause is just but the methods are violent, how should history judge the person who chose violence?

A War in Kansas

BEFORE HARPERS FERRY

John Brown was not a politician or a general. He was a deeply religious abolitionist who believed slavery was a sin so great that God demanded it be destroyed — by the sword if necessary.

He had already proven he meant it. In Bleeding Kansas, Brown and his sons dragged five pro-slavery settlers from their homes and killed them at Pottawatomie Creek. To his enemies he was a murderer; to himself, an instrument of God's justice.

John Brown — daguerreotype, c. 1846–47, public domain (National Portrait Gallery).

John Brown

THE MAN

He posed for this portrait with his hand raised, as if swearing an oath.

John Brown — daguerreotype, c. 1846–47, public domain (National Portrait Gallery).

The Raid

OCTOBER 16, 1859

Brown's plan was audacious and desperate: seize the federal arsenal at Harpers Ferry, Virginia, hand out its thousands of weapons to enslaved people, and ignite a massive uprising across the South.

It failed almost immediately. The enslaved did not rise — most never even knew he was coming. Brown and his men were trapped in the arsenal's engine house, and U.S. Marines under Robert E. Lee stormed it within 36 hours.

The engine house at Harpers Ferry ("John Brown's Fort") — photograph, public domain (West Virginia & Regional History Center).

The engine house — "John Brown's Fort"

THE LAST STAND

Brown and his surviving men were cornered here and captured. The little firehouse became one of the most famous buildings in America.

The engine house at Harpers Ferry ("John Brown's Fort") — photograph, public domain (West Virginia & Regional History Center).

Hanged — and Transformed

THE TRIAL

Wounded and captured, Brown was tried for treason and sentenced to hang. But in the courtroom and in the weeks before his execution on December 2, 1859, he was calm, dignified, and utterly certain he was right.

His composure stunned the nation. In the North, church bells tolled on the day he died; writers called him a saint. In the South, his raid confirmed the deepest fear — that the North wanted to arm the enslaved and destroy them. The same man, two completely different legends.

"A Premature Movement" — lithograph, c. 1859–60, public domain (Library of Congress).

JOHN BROWN · FINAL WRITTEN WORDS · DECEMBER 2, 1859

I, John Brown, am now quite certain that the crimes of this guilty land will never be purged away but with blood.

— HANDED TO A GUARD ON THE MORNING OF HIS EXECUTION

The Last Push Toward War

WHY IT MATTERS

Even Republicans like Lincoln disavowed the raid — they opposed slavery, but not armed insurrection and treason. Yet the South no longer believed them.

Harpers Ferry convinced many white Southerners that staying in the Union meant waiting for the next John Brown. Little more than a year later, they would secede. Brown had failed to free a single person — and still helped light the fuse.

Storming of the engine house, Harpers Ferry, 1859 — sketch, public domain (West Virginia & Regional History Center).

How Should History Judge Him?

YOUR TURN

You'll weigh two images made of John Brown — one mocking, one worshipful — against his own words, and practice historical interpretation: deciding, with evidence, what to make of a man history can't agree on.